

Dutch landscape

Following independence from Spain, a sense of national pride pervaded the Netherlands, and several artists began painting the countryside as a subject, rather than a backdrop. Based on sketches made outdoors, Dutch landscape paintings usually had low horizons, emphasizing cloud formations and light effects. Subjects included rivers, meadows, distant towns, the sea, paths and winter scenes. Hendrick Avercamp (1585–1634), an early exponent, specialized in painting crowds skating on frozen lakes. From the late 1620s, artists such as Jan van Goyen (1596–1656) and Salomon van Ruysdael (1602–70) rendered atmospheric effects, and from the 1650s, more expressive compositions with stronger tonal contrasts became prominent. Lone trees, windmills and other buildings were often used to create a focus. The leading artist in this style was Jacob van Ruisdael (1628–82), whose landscapes were accentuated by large, expressive skies. One of his pupils, Meindert Hobbema (1638–1709), excelled at capturing detailed trees and woodland scenes, while Aelbert Cuyp (1620–91) painted peaceful landscapes bathed in light.



Van Ruysdael, *View of Alkmaar from the Sea*, c.1650